Why Do Some Prefer Socialism, Communism, or Capitalism?

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The ledger framework gives a structural answer to a question that is usually answered in moral or ideological terms. People do not prefer these systems because they have different values, or because they have different temperaments, or because they have been persuaded by different arguments. They prefer them because they occupy different positions in the ledger, and different positions make different systems appear beneficial.

This is not a cynical claim. It is a structural one. It says that the preference for a system is not arbitrary; it is a rational response to the position the person occupies in the relations that the system would organize. Change the position, and the preference often changes. This is why the same person can be a socialist in one context and a capitalist in another, and why the same class can be revolutionary in one decade and conservative in the next.

The Three Systems as Ledger Configurations

The framework first requires that we define the three systems precisely, not as ideologies but as configurations of the ledger.

Capitalism is a configuration in which:

- The means of production are privately owned.
- The allocation of resources is determined by markets.
- The relations between owners and workers are contractual.
- Exit costs are low for capital and high for labor.
- The legitimacy regime justifies the outcome as the result of free exchange.

Socialism is a configuration in which:

- The means of production are socially owned (by the state, by cooperatives, or by the community).
- The allocation of resources is determined by planning, by markets, or by a mix.
- The relations between producers and the community are mediated by institutions.
- Exit costs are equalized by public provision.
- The legitimacy regime justifies the outcome as the result of collective choice.

Communism is a configuration in which:

- The means of production are commonly owned (no private property in the means of production).
- The allocation of resources is determined by need, not by exchange.
- The relations between people are unmediated by classes or states.
- Exit costs are eliminated by the abolition of the conditions that create them.
- The legitimacy regime justifies the outcome as the result of the abolition of the con itself.

These are ideal types. Real systems are mixtures. But the ideal types allow us to identify the positions that make each system attractive.

The Position That Prefers Capitalism

Who prefers capitalism? The framework identifies four positions.

First, those who own capital. For the owners of capital, capitalism is a system in which their resources are productive, their returns are protected, and their exit costs are low. They can move their capital to where it is most valued, and they can capture the surplus that the market generates. Capitalism is the system that maximizes the return to capital, and the owners of capital prefer it for the same reason.

Second, those who have skills that the market values. For the skilled professional, the entrepreneur, and the innovator, capitalism is a system in which their skills are rewarded. The market prices their contributions, and the price is high. They prefer capitalism because it is the system in which their contribution is most visible and most rewarded.

Third, those who have low exit costs. For those who can move—geographically, professionally, or financially—capitalism is a system that rewards mobility. The mobile actor can leave a bad relation and find a better one. Capitalism is the system of exit, and those with exit options prefer it.

Fourth, those who benefit from the legitimacy regime. For those who believe that the market outcome is just—that the successful deserve their success and the unsuccessful deserve their failure—capitalism is a system that confirms their worldview. The legitimacy regime justifies their position, and they prefer the system that justifies them.

The four positions are not the same. A worker with a valuable skill may prefer capitalism even though she does not own capital, because her skill gives her market power. An entrepreneur with low exit costs may prefer capitalism even though she is not wealthy, because her mobility gives her options. The preference for capitalism is not limited to the owners of capital; it extends to all those whose position in the ledger is advantaged by the market.

The Position That Prefers Socialism

Who prefers socialism? The framework identifies four positions.

First, those who sell their labor and have little bargaining power. For the worker whose labor is the only asset, and whose bargaining power is low, capitalism is a system in which the

owner captures most of the surplus. Socialism is a system in which the surplus is distributed more equally, and the worker's position is improved. The worker prefers socialism because it is the system that improves her position.

Second, those who bear the cost of market failure. For those who are unemployed, sick, disabled, elderly, or otherwise unable to participate in the market, capitalism is a system in which the market does not provide for them. Socialism is a system in which the community provides for them through public provision. They prefer socialism because it is the system that protects them.

Third, those who have high exit costs. For those who cannot move—the immobile worker, the tied tenant, the indebted farmer—capitalism is a system in which their immobility is exploited. Socialism is a system in which the immobility is compensated by public provision, and the exit costs are equalized. They prefer socialism because it is the system that compensates for their immobility.

Fourth, those who reject the legitimacy regime. For those who believe that the market outcome is not just—that the successful have not earned their success and the unsuccessful have not earned their failure—socialism is a system that challenges the legitimacy regime. They prefer socialism because it is the system that exposes the con.

The four positions are not the same. A skilled worker may prefer socialism even though she has market power, because she believes the market outcome is unjust. A public sector employee may prefer socialism even though she has low exit costs, because she believes the community should provide for the vulnerable. The preference for socialism is not limited to the poor; it extends to all those whose position in the ledger is disadvantaged by the market, or who reject the market's legitimacy.

The Position That Prefers Communism

Who prefers communism? The framework identifies three positions.

First, those who believe that the con can be abolished. For those who believe that the first allocation can be renegotiated entirely, and that a society without classes or states is possible, communism is the system that abolishes the con. They prefer communism because it is the system that denies the inevitability of the con.

Second, those who have been most exploited. For those who have borne the cost of the first allocation most heavily—the enslaved, the colonized, the dispossessed—communism is a system that promises the complete reversal of their position. They prefer communism because it is the system that promises the most radical change.

Third, those who are alienated from the existing order. For those who feel that the existing order is fundamentally illegitimate, communism is a system that offers a total alternative. They prefer communism because it is the system that denies the legitimacy of the existing con.

The three positions are not the same. A worker who believes the system can be reformed may prefer socialism; a worker who believes the system cannot be reformed may prefer communism. The preference for communism is not limited to the most exploited; it extends to all those who believe that the con can be abolished.

The Structural Pattern

The framework's pattern is now visible. The preference for a system is a function of the position in the ledger.

Capitalism is preferred by those whose position is advantaged by the market: the owners of capital, the skilled, the mobile, and those who accept the legitimacy regime. Socialism is preferred by those whose position is disadvantaged by the market: the unskilled, the immobile, the vulnerable, and those who reject the legitimacy regime. Communism is preferred by those who believe the con can be abolished: the most exploited, the most alienated, and those who reject the legitimacy regime entirely.

This is not a moral hierarchy. It is not a claim that one preference is more rational than another. It is a structural claim: the preference follows the position, and the position is a fact about the ledger.

Why the Same Person Changes Preference

The framework also explains why the same person can change preference over time.

Because the position changes. A worker who acquires a valuable skill may move from socialism to capitalism. An entrepreneur who goes bankrupt may move from capitalism to socialism. A colonized people who gain independence may move from communism to socialism to capitalism as their position improves.

Because the legitimacy regime changes. A person who believes the market outcome is just may become socialist if the market produces a crisis that exposes the con. A person who believes the market outcome is unjust may become capitalist if the market produces prosperity that benefits them.

Because the conditions change. A society that is mobilizing for war may prefer socialism; a society that is demobilizing may prefer capitalism. A society that is industrializing may prefer socialism; a society that is post-industrial may prefer capitalism.

The preference is not fixed; it responds to the conditions. The framework does not say that preferences are arbitrary. It says that they are structural, and that structure changes.

The Deeper Point

The deeper point is that the three systems are not three different moral visions. They are three different configurations of the ledger, and each configuration is preferred by the positions it advantages.

This is why the debate among the three is so intractable. Each side is not arguing about values; each side is arguing from a position. The capitalist is arguing from the position of the owner; the socialist is arguing from the position of the worker; the communist is arguing from the position of the exploited. Each is right about the ledger from their own position, and each is wrong about the ledger from the other's position.

The framework does not resolve the debate. It explains why the debate is intractable. The debate is not about which system is best in the abstract; it is about which position should be advantaged. And that question has no answer that is independent of the position.

This is the framework's deepest contribution to the debate. It says that the debate is not about values; it is about positions. And positions are facts about the ledger, not choices about morality.

The Question Behind the Debate

The framework's question is not "which system is best?" It is whose ledger is this, and for whom?

Each system produces a different ledger. Capitalism produces a ledger in which the owners of capital and the skilled are advantaged, and the unskilled, the immobile, and the vulnerable are disadvantaged. Socialism produces a ledger in which the workers and the vulnerable are advantaged, and the owners and the mobile are constrained. Communism produces a ledger in which the classes are abolished, and the position that advantaged one over another is eliminated.

The question is not which ledger is best in the abstract. The question is which ledger should be produced. And the answer depends on whose position you occupy.

This is the framework's contribution. It does not choose among the systems. It explains why people choose. And in explaining why, it makes the debate visible as a debate about positions, not about values. The debate is not about which system is true; it is about which position should be served.

The framework says: look at the position, not the ideology. The ideology is the justification; the position is the reality. And the question is always the same: whose ledger is this, and for whom?

A Closing Thought

The question of why some prefer socialism, some prefer communism, and others prefer capitalism is not a question about ideas. It is a question about positions. The preferences follow the positions, and the positions follow the ledger.

The framework does not say that one preference is better than another. It says that the preferences are structural, and that structure is what it is. The debate is intractable because each side is arguing from a position, and positions cannot be transcended by argument.

The framework's contribution is not to resolve the debate. It is to make it visible as a debate about positions, not about values. And in making it visible, it makes the question askable: which position should be served?

The answer is not given by the framework. It is given by the choice. The choice is always the same: whose ledger is this, and for whom?

For the capitalist, the answer is: the owner's, the skilled's, and the mobile's. For the socialist, the answer is: the worker's, the vulnerable's, and the immobile's. For the communist, the answer is: nobody's, because the classes are abolished.

The framework does not choose among these answers. It makes them visible, and it shows that the choice is not a matter of values but of positions. And the positions are facts about the ledger.

That is the answer. The rest is history—or its absence. And the choice of which it will be is always, in part, our own.